her experiences in West Germany remained an integral part of her personal and political story, told countless times in text and in public speeches; the story of her time in divided Berlin, however, has been told only a handful of times in public. Her autobiography was likely the first published instance in which she publicly shared details from her trip to the divided city of Berlin and the only place on record where she points to the structure others refer to as the Berlin Wall. In doing so she calls out the social boundaries endemic to American culture while maintaining her political affinity to socialist East Germany. Similarly, she draws attention to East Germany's programs of meaningful solidarity with people of color while turning away from their own repressive regime's pervasive border control. In doing so, she shifts a hyperfocus on the infamy of the Berlin Wall, bracketing and turning away from the Wall built by East Germans in Berlin toward addressing other physical and social walls in the United States and the West more broadly.

At first as an admiring visitor to East Berlin in 1966 and later as a celebrated returning public icon after her acquittal (and while writing her autobiography) in 1972, Davis would have also been familiar with the official German Democratic Republic mandate in regard to the Wall: from the eastern perspective, there was no "Berlin Wall," only, officially, an "antifascist protective rampart." In East Germany the word "wall" (*Mauer* in German) was not acceptable for everyday speech and, when possible, the structure was withdrawn from sight. Most citizens of the GDR were rarely able to approach the area of the Wall without official clearance. The regime saw itself as protecting citizens from what it deemed the scourges of capitalism and imperialism, which the East associated with, in part, Germany's Nazi past.[14] Though already aligned with leftist causes, Davis officially joined the Communist Party in 1968. In her autobiography, her reference to "the wall" and not "the Berlin Wall" places her in clear identification with East Berlin's refusal to acknowledge the existence of its own constructed sprawling walled border system for its own citizens. In her autobiography, she uses geopolitical terms such as "West Berlin" and "West Germany" but refers to "Berlin" as the "capital of the German Democratic Republic."[15] In turn, she becomes an American Berliner under selective and defiant terms.

To explore Davis's own evolution as a writer and an activist concerned with dividing walls, first this chapter reviews the representations of East and West Berlin in the mid-1960s and beyond, in the years after the crisis along